



Government

Getting Started with your Government MSc Dissertation

Dr Jill Stuart

4 December 2025

Today's Plan

- Who's who in LSE Dissertations
- Timeline overview
- What exactly is a dissertation?
- Choosing your topic
- The research question
- Literature and methods
- Thinking about structure
- Narrowing down/ making feasible
- Ethics



Who's Who in LSE Dissertations?

LSE

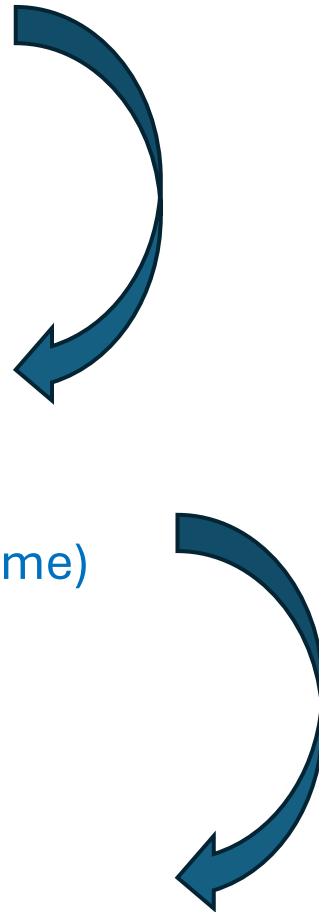
- LSE Life
- LSE Library
- Well Being Service

Government Department

- Academic Menor
- Dissertation Supervisor
- Dissertation Support Supervisor (me)
- PSS

You

- Different MSc Programmes



Who's Who: Me

- LSE MSc student from 2001-2002
- LSE PhD Student from 2003-2009
- LSE Faculty thereafter
- Since 2018 Dissertation Support Supervisor
- Specialise in helping students with research projects
- Have weekly office hours



Government



Who's Who: Government Department

- Academic Mentor
- Dissertation Supervisor
 - A good match for your topic area
 - Meet with them in the Winter and Summer terms + two 'dissertation support windows' over the summer break
 - It has to be someone within the Government Department
 - You may not get your first choice.
- PSS

TIP→ Use others' office hours. Use [LSE Experts](#). Use the GV499 Moodle Page

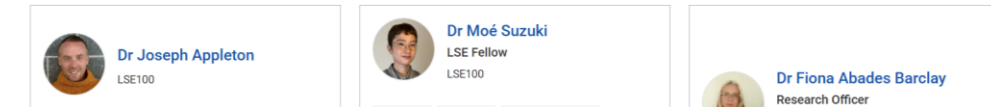
Note on looking at past dissertations

Find LSE experts

A to Z by lastname

A B C D E F G H I J K L M N O P Q R S T U V W X Y Z

Staff type + Department + Languages + [Reset filters](#)



Using past dissertations

Dissertation Library



This section provides examples of dissertations for you to view. They are listed with the permission of the student. The available dissertations on this page are meant to act as an example of style and format rather than content.

All of the dissertations in the dissertation library were awarded a Distinction. However, do note that all dissertations are different and that you could perfectly get a first with a piece of work that is very different from all those listed here. Even the best dissertations are also far from 'perfect' so it may sometimes be confusing to understand what are the strong and weak points of the examples provided. Ultimately, your supervisor can give you guidance that is both general and project-specific and will always give you more reliable recommendations than any approximative comparison between your own work and someone else's.

In addition to the below dissertation library, we also recommend viewing some of the prize-winning dissertations submitted by Department of Government students in the last few years. These are published to the general public on the [Master's Research](#) page, again only with the permission of the student.



Dissertation Database - 2023/24



Dissertation Database - 2022/23



Dissertation Database - 2021/22



Dissertation Database - 2020/21



Role of the dissertation supervisor

- Help you focus and clarify your research question
- Provide personalised advice on methods and literature
- Comments on the general plan and structure of your work
- Help you find other LSE experts to consult during their office hours



Government

Who's Who: LSE 'School Level'

- LSE Life
 - Offer Dissertation Sessions Spring Term weeks 1-7
 - One on One Sessions

Your master's dissertation with LSE LIFE

A research project has many stages and the end product - a dissertation - is a major piece of writing. There's a lot to think about, but LSE LIFE can help you find your way with resources, events, and one-to-one advice at every step of the way! We're open and doing things every weekday, throughout the whole academic year and summer break, until your hand-in deadline.

Get off to a good start

Develop your ideas and research story

Find, review, and use literature

- LSE Library
 - Our Librarian: Paul Horsler p.n.horsler@lse.ac.uk

- Well Being



Who's Who: You

MSc in Political Science (Conflict Studies and Comparative Politics)



MSc Political Science (Global Politics)



MSc Political Science (Political Behaviour)



MSc Political Science (MSc Political Science and Political Economy)



MSc Public Policy and Administration



MSc Political Theory



MSc Regulation



What you have in common: “GV499”

TIP→ Many of you will have *not* done a project like this before

Timeline

On GV499 Moodle:

An overview of the GV499 Dissertation Process		
Term	Date	Event
Autumn Term (Wks 7-11)	Varies by Programme	Programme-specific Introductory Dissertation Sessions. Each MSc programme will organise an introductory workshop offering basic guidance on dissertation research. PPA and Regulation workshops take place within GV4E9 and GV488 core courses.
Autumn Term (Wk 10)	Wednesday, 3 December 2025 (4-6pm) and Thursday, 4 December 2025 (2-4pm)	Department of Government Dissertation Sessions: these sessions will focus on the overall process and timeline for the dissertation and the key aspects of research design and methodology. Students should sign-up for one of these sessions: details will be provided by the MSc Programmes Support team.
Winter Term (Wks 1-5)	Monday 19 January - Friday 20 February 2026	Students are encouraged to discuss dissertations with their academic mentors in the early Winter Term (January-February) and to consider potential dissertation supervisors.
Winter Term (Wks 2-4)	Varies by Programme	Second Dissertation Session
Winter Term (Wk 5)	Friday 20 February 2026	Submission of Dissertation Supervisor Request Form. Students will be invited to complete a Dissertation Supervision Form via Moodle, due by the end of week 5. This form will ask students for a very brief outline of their dissertation topic and possible research question to assist in matching students to appropriate supervisors. The allocations will be confirmed via email in Week 6.
Winter Term (Wk 6)	Friday 27 February 2026	Allocation of Dissertation Supervisors. Students are expected to start meeting regularly with their allocated dissertation supervisor in preparation for the submission of the formal dissertation prospectus late March. Please speak to your supervisor about this early on.
Winter Term (Wk 11)	Monday 30 March 2026	Deadline for submission of dissertation prospectus of around 1000 words. The prospectus is an outline of the dissertation plan. Please speak to your supervisor about this early on.
Winter Term / Spring Term	Monday 2 March - Friday 15 May 2026	Students are expected to continue to meet with their dissertation supervisor following the submission of their prospectus, in order to discuss the key points mentioned in their prospectus and agree the topic and approach for their dissertation, in preparation for the submission of the Dissertation Topic Approval form.
Spring Term	Friday 15 May 2026	Deadline for submission of the Dissertation Topic Approval form. In this form, students will be asked to confirm that they have agreed the topic and the approach for their dissertation with their supervisor and to enter the agreed title of their dissertation.
Spring Term	Friday 15 May – Friday 19 June 2026	Following the submission of the Dissertation Topic Approval form, students are expected to continue to discuss the development of their dissertation proposal with their supervisors until the end of formal dissertation supervision at the end of the Spring Term.
Spring Term (Wks 1-7)	Tuesday 5 May - Friday 19 June 2026	LSE LIFE runs a series of dissertation workshops in the Spring Term. Students can sign up via the LSE Training and Development System.

Timeline: What's next?

- Before end of this term: Programme specific session
- Early next term: Discuss topic and supervisors with academic mentor
- **16 Feb:** Submit Dissertation Supervisor Request Form, “a very brief outline of their dissertation topic and possible research question”
- **By 27 Feb:** Assigned Dissertation Supervisor
- **30 March:** Submit Dissertation prospectus—around 1,000 words, outline of dissertation



Government

What exactly *is* the dissertation?

- A substantial *independent* piece of academic work on a topic of interest to you
- 25 per cent of the total assessment of your MSc programme
- 10,000 words
- Due 18 August 2026
- Original Project

Tip→ You are learning the research process as well as your topic in depth

Tip→ There is a lot of variety (don't let your colleagues/ friends 'throw you off!')



Government

What do we mean by 'independent'?

- You define the research question
- You choose the method(s)
- You develop a personal answer to the question
- Your opportunity to engage and apply your own interests, with the guidance of your dissertation supervisor.



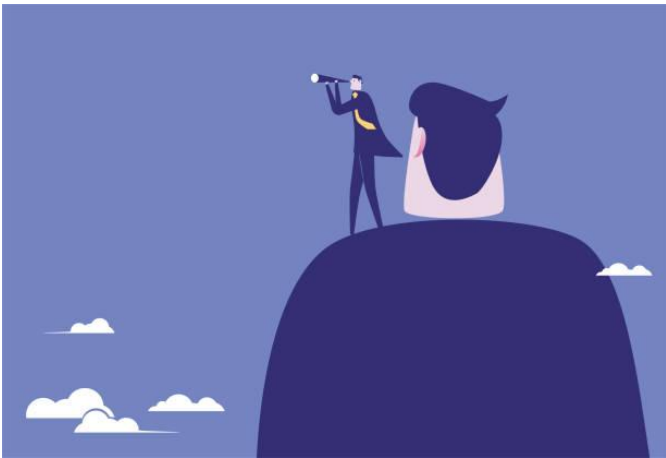
Government

What do we mean by ‘original’?

The responsibility to root our research in what came before

- “Stand on the shoulders of giants”
- Tree branch analogy

TIP → This also helps with narrowing down your topic



Choosing a topic

- What interests you?
- How it relates to your other courses
- Feasibility
- Connections, resources, language
- The hardest part is not deciding what to focus on, but what to exclude

TIP→ How it relates to future career?



An underwater photograph showing a clear blue ocean. Sunlight rays (neutrals) penetrate from the surface, creating a bright, hazy area in the upper left. Numerous small, clear bubbles are suspended in the water, particularly concentrated near the surface where they appear to be rising. The overall color palette is various shades of blue, from deep navy at the bottom to bright cyan near the surface.

Ocean analogy

Research Question: finding your rock



- Apply an existing explanation/model in a new context
- Argue that an important topic (or case) has been overlooked – and proceed to provide systematic evidence ('A Gap')
- Show that insights, evidence, and tools used in one field can be can help solve a problem in the field you are interested in
- Argue/ build upon a previous study or author
- Reject some aspects of an explanation or hypothesis, with a proposal for an alternative approach
- Replicate an existing study with a new case or new data
- Address a theoretical perspective or model that you strongly agree/disagree with

What vs Why Questions

TIP → Why we focus so much on the RQ

What question = description

- e.g. Q: What did Biden do to win the US Presidential election?
- Answer: he won more electoral college votes



Why = analysis

- e.g. Why did Biden win the US Presidential election?
- Requires analytical answer

Research Question

From GV499 Moodle:

- A research question needs to address a theoretical or an empirical topic, or both.
- Think closely whether you are trying to make a theoretical contribution (i.e. a new idea on how the world works) or an empirical one (i.e. where you take existing theories and put them to an empirical test).

TIP→ Most of you will have an empirical focus, but make theoretical reflections

Evolving questions...

My personal experience...

Writing and re-writing

- “Which International Relations theory best explains outer space politics, and why?”
- “Between realism and liberalism, which best explains outer space politics and why?”
- Final question: “Between realism and liberalism, which best explains outer space politics from 1959-1967?”

The research question

TIP→ Can I change my question?

- With agreement from your dissertation supervisor, you may be permitted to change your dissertation topic or title after your Dissertation Topic Approval Form has been submitted.
- However you will not be permitted to make major changes after the end of the Summer Term.
- You may make minor amendments to your title, providing the basic topic remains unchanged.

(GV499 Moodle)

Literature and sources



Government

➤ *Primary source*

- a document that was written during the events that are studied
- A news story
- A primary report, such as an NGO
- an interview with a person
- Primary data sources

➤ *Secondary source*

- an academic study, journalistic account, NGO report, or other *interpretations* of the event *that are removed from it*.

Tip → How many sources should I use?

Tip → Read strategically

Choosing your method(s)



Government

Most programmes are methodologically pluralist

‘What is the best way to answer my research question?’

- Quantitative
- Qualitative
- Or... mixed methods

TIP→ Methods are important, but you are not writing a ‘methodology’ dissertation (What, How, and Why)

TIP→ Find a textbook: many suggestions on GV499

Choosing your method(s)

Useful Readings

General

- Dunleavy, P. (1986) Studying for a Degree in the Social Sciences, Macmillan. (See Chapter 5: Writing a Dissertation)
- Denscombe, M. (2007) The Good Research Guide: for small-scale social research projects. Maidenhead: Open University Press. H61 D41
- Dunleavy, P. (2003) Authoring a PhD: how to plan, draft, write and finish a doctoral thesis or dissertation. Basingstoke: Palgrave-Macmillan. LB2369 D92
- Grix, J. (2004) The Foundations of Research. Houndmills : Palgrave Macmillan LB2369 G87
- May, T. (1997) Social research: Issues, methods and processes, Open University Press.
- Robson, C. (1993) Real world research: A resource for social scientists and practitioner-researchers, Oxford University Press.
- Rudestam, K. and Newton, R. (2001) Surviving Your Dissertation: a comprehensive guide to content and process. London: Sage. LB2369 R91
- Wallimann, N. (2001) Your research project: A step-by-step guide for the first-time researcher, Sage.

Research design textbooks

- Based on MY400+more specific readings on research design in political science
- Robson, Colin (2011, 3rd edition). Real World Research. John Wiley.
- King, Gary, Keohane, R. & Verba, Sydney (1994). Designing Social Inquiry. Princeton University Press.
- Geertz, Gary and Mahoney, James (2012). A Tale of Two Cultures: Qualitative and Quantitative Research in the Social Sciences. Princeton University Press.
- Trochim, William and Donnelly, James (2008, 3rd edition). The Research Methods Knowledge Base. Atomic Dog.
- Gerring, John (2012, 2nd edition). Social Science Methodology: A Unified Framework. Cambridge University Press.
- Seale, Clive (ed.) (2004). Social Research Methods: A Reader. Routledge.
- Hancké, Bob (2009). Intelligent research design: a guide for beginning researchers in the social sciences. Oxford ; New York : Oxford University Press
- Van Evera, Stephen (1997). Guide to Methods for Students of Political Science. Ithaca: Ithaca : Cornell UP. Print.
- Bruter, Michael, and Martin Lodge (2013). Political Science Research Methods in Action. N.p.: Houndmills, Basingstoke, Hampshire : Palgrave

Qualitative Approaches



Government

- Understand the reasons, opinions and/or motivations around a specific issue
- Focused on gaining deep, rich insights into phenomena within their natural settings
- Emphasizing subjective experiences, meanings, and interpretations
- Using words, images, gestures, opinions, ideas, customs, beliefs
- Examples: Comparative studies, discourse analysis, case studies, document analysis, theoretical analysis, critical approaches

Quantitative approaches



Government

- Test hypotheses and establish patterns through analysis that involve numerical data.
- Calculate averages, predict outcomes, or generalize results to a larger population
- You may collect your own data (primary data) or use pre-existing data sources (secondary data)

TIP→ Most of you will use secondary data. This may come from more than one source.

- Examples: Regressions, QCA, T-tests, inferential statistics

Structure



Government

Most common structure:

Abstract

Table of contents

Introduction

Literature Review

Theoretical Framework

Methods

Body (results/findings, analysis and arguments)

Conclusion (implications and limitations)

TIP→ There is a lot of variety

TIP→ There is no 'magic word count for each section

Narrowing down/ making feasible

- Focus-down model (Dunleavy 1986)
- Opening-out model (Dunleavy 1986)
- Hourglass Model

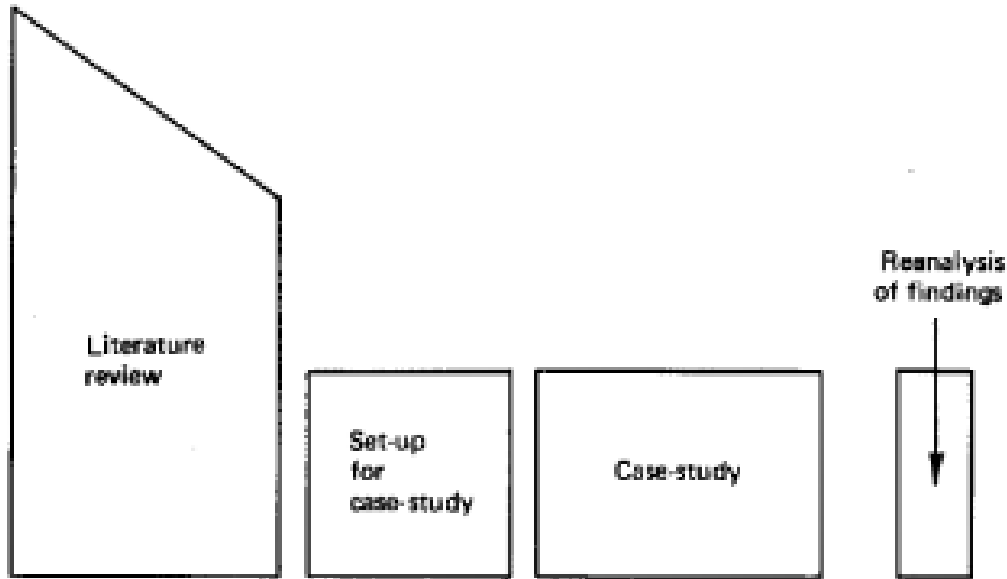


Figure 5.1: The 'focus-down' model for case-study dissertations

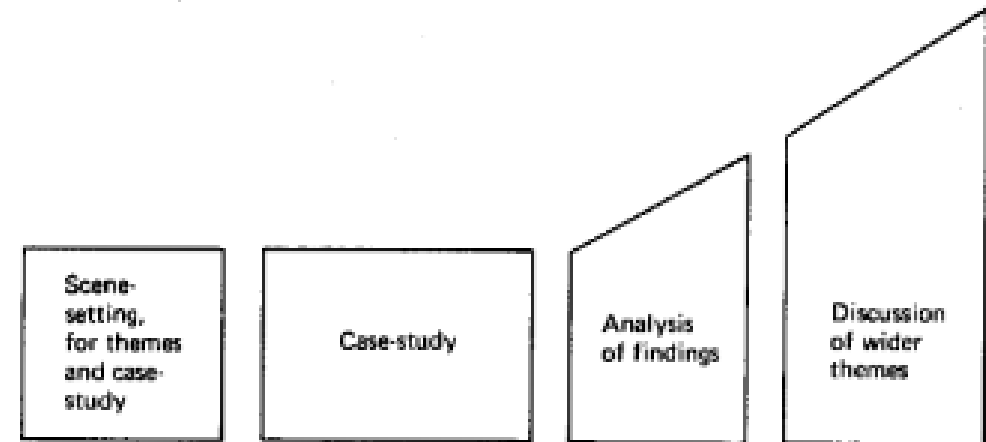


Figure 5.2: The 'opening-out' model for case-study dissertations

Narrowing down/ making feasible

Consider breadth vs depth payoffs

TIP→ You are not expected to cover everything—part of your challenge (and opportunity) is to put boundaries on what you are covering

TIP→ Remember you can put in ‘limitations/ recommendations for future research’ in your conclusion

Research Ethics



- For primary research collection only
- This includes scraping from social media
- Discuss with your supervisor

TIP → Don't be intimidated by the ethics form

Research Ethics



If you are planning on undertaking some primary research as part of your dissertation or thesis you should first read the [Research Ethics in a Nutshell](#) and the [Instructions](#) documents and discuss these plans with your dissertation supervisor. Although any particular empirical investigation may be modest in scope, if it involves human participants, it is essential that those conducting the research consider and address any ethical implications that may arise. Where the dissertation supervisor deems it appropriate, students should submit a research ethics form via the [Research Ethics Submission System](#). Further information is available on the [Research Ethics](#) webpage.

If a student has specific concerns or queries about research ethics they should speak first with their dissertation supervisor and then with

A reminder of next steps

- Think about your topic area
- Start doing some broad, strategic reading
- Meet with your academic mentor
- Attend programme-specific sessions
- **16 Feb:** Dissertation Supervisor Request Form
- **By 27 Feb:** Assigned Dissertation Supervisor
- **30 March:** Dissertation prospectus

Thank you, and questions!



Government